

Explicit Meaning - Study Guide

Find what the text actually states, especially when a long passage contains many similar details.

Learning goal

Identify directly stated facts, rules, actions, reasons, and conditions without adding an inference.

1. What this skill is

Explicit meaning is information the author states directly. You do not need to read between the lines. Your job is to find the exact detail that answers the question and preserve its meaning.

2. Explicit vs. inferred

Type	Example
Explicit	The notice says the office closes at 4:30 p.m. Therefore, 4:30 p.m. is directly stated.
Inferred	The doors were locked at 4:45 p.m. You may infer the office was closed, but that is a conclusion from evidence.

3. How exam-style questions ask it

- According to the passage, which statement is true?
- Which statement is directly supported by the passage?
- What does the passage state about ___?
- According to the notice, when / where / why / how does ___ happen?

4. The 3-step method

1. **Identify the target.** Is the question asking about a time, person, rule, reason, action, amount, or condition?
2. **Locate the matching idea.** Find the part of the passage that discusses that exact target.
3. **Verify every word.** Reject any option that adds, removes, or changes a condition.

5. Long-passage strategy

Target → Scan → Verify

On a 500-900 word passage, do not reread everything for a detail question. Turn the question into a search target first: a name, date, rule, location, number, or condition. Scan for that target, then read the surrounding sentence carefully.

If the question asks about a policy exception, scanning only for the topic word is not enough. Read the whole sentence because words such as **only, unless, before, after, some, most, may, must** can change the answer.

6. Qualifier words that change meaning

- above / below / at least / no more than
- before / after / during / beginning on
- some / most / all / only
- may / must / should / can
- except / unless / if / when

Example: "Orders above \$50 qualify for free delivery."

Supported: A \$51 order qualifies.

Not supported: A \$50 order qualifies. *Above \$50* does not mean \$50 or more.

7. When two choices seem possible

Ask which choice preserves the text **most exactly**. One answer may repeat a real detail but answer a different question. Another may be reasonable in real life but not stated.

8. Common traps

Trap	What it does
True elsewhere	Repeats a real detail from the passage, but not the detail the question asks for.
Reasonable inference	Could be true, but the text never states it directly.
Changed condition	Changes a time, amount, group, sequence, or exception.
Overstatement	The passage says <i>some</i> or <i>may</i> , but the option says <i>all</i> or <i>always</i> .
Contradiction	Conflicts with a directly stated detail.

9. Worked example

The library will close its second-floor study room from March 4 through March 8 while new lighting is installed. The first-floor reading room and computer area will remain open during regular hours.

Which statement is directly supported?

- A. The entire library will close for five days.
- B. The second-floor study room will be unavailable from March 4 through March 8.
- C. New computers will be installed on the first floor.
- D. The reading room will close earlier than usual.

Best answer: B. It preserves the location and dates exactly. A expands one room into the whole library. C invents a new event. D contradicts "regular hours."

10. Diagnostic help

- **You keep choosing true-but-wrong details:** restate the exact question target before scanning.
- **You miss conditions:** circle words such as *only*, *unless*, *before*, *after*, *at least*.
- **You infer too much:** ask, "Can I point to the sentence that states this?"

11. Quick check

Volunteers may pick up garden tools from the community shed after 8:00 a.m. on Saturdays. Tools must be returned by 6:00 p.m. the same day.

Which statement is directly supported?

- A. Tools may be kept overnight.
- B. The shed closes at exactly 6:00 p.m.
- C. Tools must be returned on Saturday.
- D. Anyone may pick up tools before 8:00 a.m.

Answer: C. "The same day" refers to Saturday. The passage never states the shed's closing time.

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